

Shift Happens: Merge & Serve (MERGE)

Hook / Trend fit (1–2 lines).

I based this game off Gen Z job hunt memes and unemployment memes which also makes this game relatable to the Gen Z

Story:

The game follows an IT student whose just graduated, but he couldn't get any IT job, so he's working for a fast food restaurant to survive while looking for his dream job.

The game could start by showing the main character being looked down on by someone like a high school teacher which could also motivate the player to go through with the game til the end.

The game also has multiple chapter with promotion but that doesn't mean the game would get easier in the later chapter, that would be boring we should make it look like the games easier but its actually getting harder(make the restaurant hire more employee but also increase the number of customers)

The end, the main character get his/her dream job notification while on a shift dealing with an annoying costumer, that's when the Main character resign and teach the annoying customer a lesson.

Core gameplay (90% — MERGE)

- Board: 6×8. Drag to merge 3 identical tiles → higher tier (merge-5 spawns a Perk Token you can tap for a one-off bonus).
- Spawners: *Prep Crates* periodically spawn tier-1 ingredients & tools.
- Orders: A queue of Order Cards (e.g., Burger + Fries + Drink). When required components exist on board, an auto-crafted Meal Box appears.
- Constraints: spill tiles (block drag), clutter (occupies space; merge into Trash Bag to clear).
- Win condition: finish serving orders before Shift Timer ends while keeping Customer Patience high enough.

Auxiliary gameplay (10% — quick, meaningful)

A) Serve Flick (1–2s): flick Meal Box along a lane as a timing check.

- *Perfect* = +patience buffer on that customer & +tip multiplier; *Miss* = base serve.

B) Station Calibration (5–7s, only when you merge a tool): hold in green zone / tap-to-tempo to “activate” the tool and show what it does:

- Coffee Machine: slows patience decay (Perfect = longer).
- POS Upgrade: +tip chance/amount this shift.
- Ice Machine: freeze one customer's patience briefly.

- **Playlist Speaker:** –% stress cost for this level.

The 10% minis are short, but they visibly change the board/economy, explaining why merged items matter.

Dual timers (per your spec)

- **Shift Timer:** level duration and grading.
- **Customer Patience:** per-order decay; can be slowed/frozen by calibrated tools, boosted by Perfect Serve.

Customer states & tips

- **Good (≥70% patience on serve):** \$10 tip guaranteed.
- **Normal (30–70%):** 50% chance \$5 tip.
- **Frustrated (<30%):** \$0 tip.
- **Leave (hits 0):** lose order; if >3 leave in a shift → **Manager Scold** at summary.

Tip modifiers: Perfect Serve (+20%), POS (+x%), events (+y%).

Stress → Energy (your revised system)

- **Meter:** 0–100%. If it reaches 100%, you must wait for regen.
- **Regen:** baseline +1% / 3 min (tunable). Pauses in-level, continues offline.

Stress cost by performance (applied at end of level):

- **Great shift:** 0–5%
- **Good shift:** 10%
- **Bad shift:** 15–20%
- **Horrendous:** 30% (>3 leave), plus *Scold* flag

Modifiers: Perfect Serve (–2% each, cap –6%), Coffee active ≥60% of shift (–5%), *Scold* (+5%), first-time clear (–5%).

UX: pre-level shows projected costs; post-level line-item (e.g., *Base 10 – Perfects 4 – Coffee 5 = 1%*).

Power-ups (buyable/gifted; all expressed via merge chains)

- **Auto-Prep Station:** guarantees 2–3 seeded match-3s at start.
- **Coffee Machine:** slows patience decay for the shift.
- **POS Upgrade:** raises tip chance/amount.

- **Playlist Speaker:** -5% stress cost this level.
- **Cleaner Spray:** clears all spills once.
- **Shift Buddy:** next 2 merges duplicate the result.

Money & sinks (more ideas, as you asked)

Income per level = base wage + tips ± performance bonus.

Regular expenses / sinks:

- **Rent every 7 levels (fixed bill).**
- **Transit pass every 5 levels (reduces chance of starting with extra customers).**
- **Phone/Internet bill (monthly chapter boss): failing to pay → -spawn rate for Prep Crates next 2 levels.**
- **Self-care (Gym pass / Meditation app / Night out): cost money, reduce stress now (-10%/-20%) or boost regen (+50% for 1h).**
- **Room décor (cosmetic collection; optional set bonuses to regen +10%).**
- **Certifications / Online courses (CompTIA-style): unlock new tool chains & better crate tables; required for later chapters.**
- **PC upgrade/Repair: unlocks “Portfolio Merge” chain (see below).**
- **Networking event ticket: increases Interview Slot spawn chance on milestone levels.**

Example merge trees (few, memorable)

Food lines (orders):

- **Bun → Bun Pack → Bun Crate**
- **Patty → Cooked Patty → Signature Patty**
- **Potato → Fries → Loaded Fries**
- **Syrup → Soda → Large Soda**

Completing an Order Card consumes items and spawns a Meal Box.

Tool lines (buffs via Calibration):

- **Bean Bag → Coffee Pot → Coffee Machine (slow patience)**
- **Receipt Roll → Barcode Scanner → POS Upgrade (+tips)**
- **Ice Tray → Ice Bin → Ice Machine (freeze patience)**
- **Mop Head → Mop → Cleaner Spray (clear spills)**

Career meta (between chapters):

- **Code Snippet → Mini App → Portfolio Project → Résumé Update**
 - **Certificate Piece → Course Cert → Tech Cert**
 - **Referral Note → Interview Slot → Offer Letter (*final goal*)**
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Sample level (Ch.2-L6)

- **Goal: Serve 6 orders; ≤ 2 leave.**
 - **Start: 2 Spill tiles; Coffee Pot on board; crates spawn every 3 turns.**
 - **Beat: Merge Coffee Machine → Calibration (Perfect = -25% patience decay for 25s).**
 - **3-Star: ≥ 4 “Good” serves & no scold.**
 - **Stress cost: likely 10% base – (Perfects/coffee modifiers).**
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